



Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

May 2026

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Quick Start Guide — Orchestrating with Empathy

Rostas a Better way to Roster Volunteers

Orchestrating with Empathy: The Rostas Quick Start Guide

A complete system for building rosters, managing replacements, and protecting your volunteers' energy.



NotebookLM

Scheduling that Respects Real Life

Rostas acts as an empathy engine. It acknowledges that availability fluctuates, energy levels differ, people get sick, and everyone needs a break.



No Login Friction

Personalized, secure links sent straight to inboxes.



Energy Protection

Built-in frequency caps limit how often a volunteer is scheduled.



Stress-Free Opt-Outs

One-tap 'Can't make it' buttons for when life happens.



Respectful Boundaries

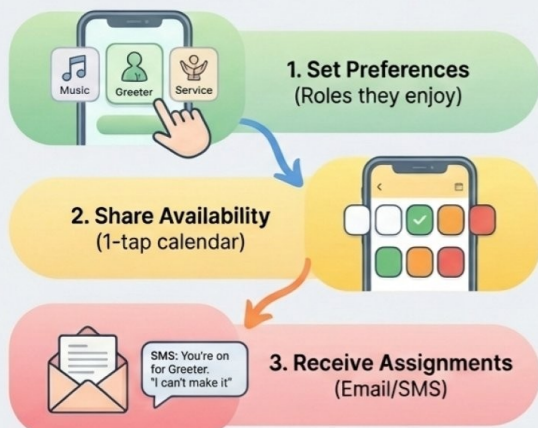
Quiet Hours automatically pause SMS notifications between 9:00 PM and 7:00 AM.

NotebookLM

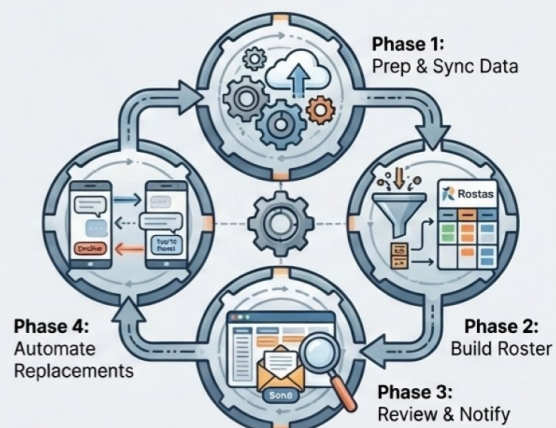
Two Perspectives, One Seamless System

Rostas handles complex logic behind the scenes so the volunteer experience remains distilled to just three low-friction steps.

The Volunteer Journey



The Coordinator Engine



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Coordinator Capabilities at a Glance

System access is purposefully distilled to protect data integrity. Infoodle acts as the ultimate source of truth for membership.

	Roster Coordinator	Overall Coordinator	Tech Support
Sync volunteers from Infoodle	✓	✓	✓
Sync roster types	✓	✓	✓
View/Edit volunteer data	✓	✓	✓
Build/Edit rosters	✓	✓	✓
Manage Replacements	✓	✓	✓
Sync volunteers from Infoodle		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster		✓	✓
Add new volunteers/roster types		✓	✓
Apps Script / Technical changes			✓

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Step 0 & 1: Laying the Groundwork

Before asking volunteers for availability, the system requires a synchronized foundation. Never build on outdated data.

Step 0: Refresh Calendar

0. Refresh calendar

Function: Recalculates season dates and overlays NZ public and school holidays.



Rule: Always run after editing season dates or starting a new cycle.

Step 1: Sync Volunteers

1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle

Function: Pulls fresh volunteer data and group memberships from Infoodle (runs automatically at 2 AM, or manually). **Note:** Overall Coordinator task.



Warning: Infoodle is the source of truth. Name changes or new volunteers must be added there first, then synced.

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Step 2 & 3b: Setting Preferences and Protecting Energy

Rostas needs to know what people are willing to do, and how often they can safely do it without burning out.

Step 2: Role Preferences

☒ Guitar Acoustic Yes, I do this	☐ Happy to fill in Happy to fill in
☒ Sound Tech Not for me	☒ Electric Not for me
☒ Electric Not for me	☒ Drums Not for me
☒ Keys Not for me	☒ Worship Leader Yes, I do this
☒ Vocals Yes, I do this	☒ Bass Not for me

'Yes, I do this' points to 'Guitar Acoustic' and 'Vocals'.
'Happy to fill in' points to 'Happy to fill in'.
'Not for me' points to 'Bass'.

Sent via personalized link, or set manually by Coordinator.

Step 3b: Frequency Caps

Max Days Rostered

4 Days Per Month

Sets a monthly maximum per roster type (Defaults to 4 for weekly, 2 for fortnightly)

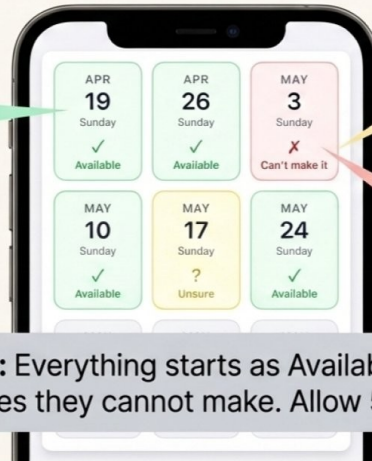
Insight: The engine strictly enforces this. Once a cap is reached, the system will not assign them, even if they marked themselves 'Available'.

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Step 3: Gathering Availability Without Friction

Sent 2–3 weeks before a season begins. Volunteers receive a secure link requiring no passwords. They simply tap dates to cycle through their status.

Available: The default starting state for all dates.



Unsure: Signals caution to the coordinator.

Can't make it: Immediately removes them from the scheduling pool for that date.

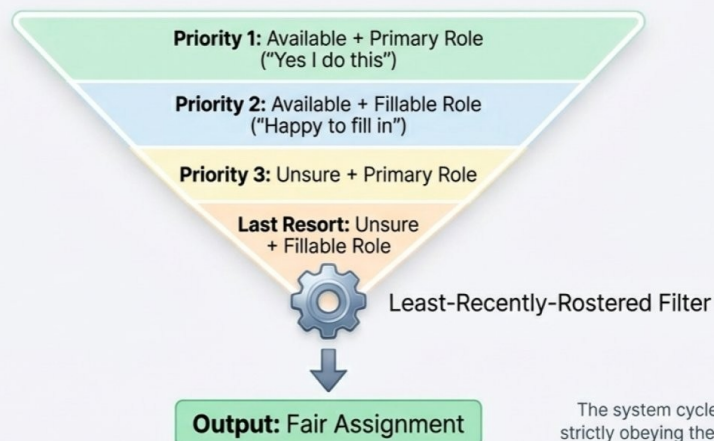


Clever User Interface: Everything starts as Available — volunteers only spend time changing the dates they cannot make. Allow 5–7 days for responses.

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Step 4: The Roster Engine Logic

The automated engine (building 8 weeks by default) doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a strict priority matrix to make intelligent, fair assignments.



The system cycles through this logic while strictly obeying the monthly frequency caps.

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Never dispatch notifications blindly. Review the Global Roster Day View first to address gaps and ensure accuracy.

Unfilled
No suitable volunteer found. Requires manual intervention before sending.

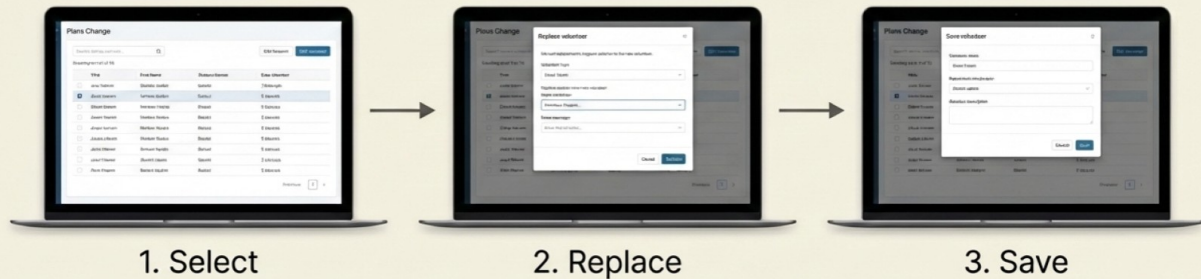
Warning: Do not run Step 5 (Send Notifications) until all Red 'Unfilled' slots are managed or acknowledged.

Verify the formatting, then release the schedule. Every assignment email doubles as a safety net if circumstances change.

Empowering the volunteer: Sickness happens. This button instantly triggers the automated rescue chain.

When Plans Change: Manual Interventions

Manual replacements are required when plans change unexpectedly. After selecting the new volunteer to fill the gap, ensure you save the changes to update the roster

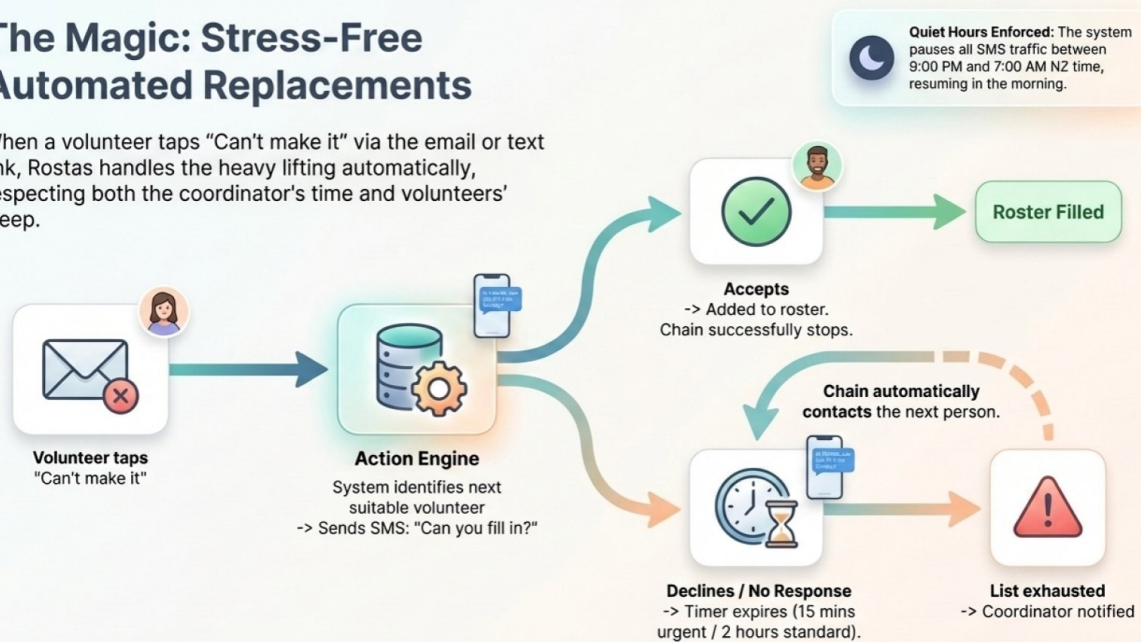


Manual replacements trigger an automated notification to the new volunteer

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The Magic: Stress-Free Automated Replacements

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" via the email or text link, Rostas handles the heavy lifting automatically, respecting both the coordinator's time and volunteers' sleep.



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Status Dashboard: Checking Notifications

You can check the status of notifications sent from Rostas in the Status Dashboard. If an error occurs you can click the email tech support button to get problems sorted.

Status Dashboard			
Notification Type	Recipient	Status	Time Sent
SMS Request	Sarah T.	Delivered	10:00 AM
SMS Reminder	John B.	Failed	10:05 AM
Email Notification	Emily R.	Sent	10:15 AM
Email Notification	Emily R.	Sent	10:15 AM
SMS Reminder	Sarah T.	Delivered	10:15 AM

 **Email Tech Support**

Click to report errors

Best Practice: you can check that Rostas is doing what it's meant to do in the Status Dashboard after running commands. If there is an error and the message doesn't help you fix it you can contact the tech support person. The email link automatically includes any error log.

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Under the Hood: Managing Settings

Global settings dictate system behavior. Know what you can safely adjust and what requires technical support.



Safe to Adjust

- Coordinator names & emails
- Reminder timing (minutes between texts)
- Email and SMS message wording templates



Leave to Tech Owner

SMS_ENABLED (Controls live delivery)
WEBAPP_URL (Breaks volunteer links)
INFOODLE_GROUP_MAP (Breaks database sync)
ROSTER_FREEZE_WEEKS (Protects past dates)



Support Card

Contact Guy for anything in the red column or for adding entirely new roster types.

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Summary: Best Practices for Empathetic Rostering

Master the system by following these four foundational rules to empower your volunteers and simplify your scheduling.



Database Sync

1. Sync First

Always pull fresh Infoodle data and run Step 0 on season changes before building.



Calendar Clock

2. Give Notice

Send availability requests 2-3 weeks early to respect people's planning time.



Traffic Light

3. Review Before Sending

Never dispatch notifications blindly. Check for 'Red' unfilled slots first.



Interconnected Nodes

4. Trust the Chain

Let the automated SMS system handle sick calls and replacements.

Empower your volunteers. Simplify your scheduling.

 NotebookLM

A complete guide to building rosters, managing replacements, and protecting your volunteers' energy.

Knox Church Waitara

Introduction

Rostas is the coordinator app for managing Church & Community volunteer rosters. It currently connects to the Infoodle database to access volunteer data, and handles notifications, reminders, and SMS replacements automatically using the Twilio SMS service (with ClickSend retained as a switchable fallback). Both these services are paid services requiring a subscription.

This guide covers everything you need: from collecting availability through to handling replacements. **Part A** introduces Rostas with a video and overview. **Part B** covers Roster Coordinator tasks. **Part C** covers additional Overall Coordinator tasks for those who have database access. **Part D** covers expert/technical tasks requiring Apps Script access.

New in May 2026 — Relational Rostering. Rostas can now pair household members and preferred buddies on the same service dates, so families serve together and friends can offer to fill in for one another. See Relational Rostering for the full feature, and Quick Controls for the global on/off toggle.

Who Can Do What

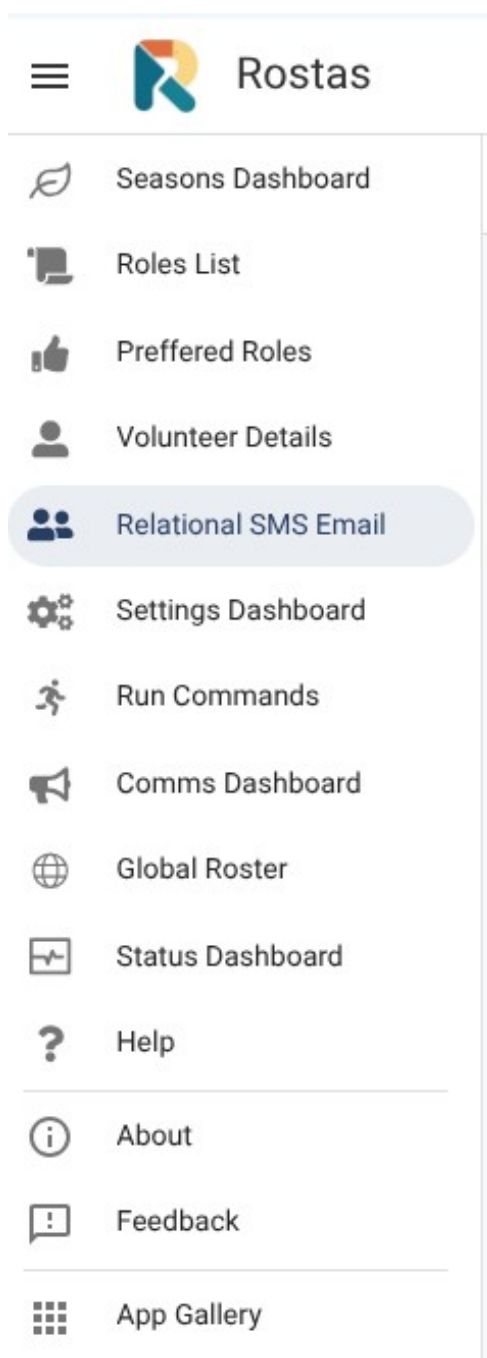
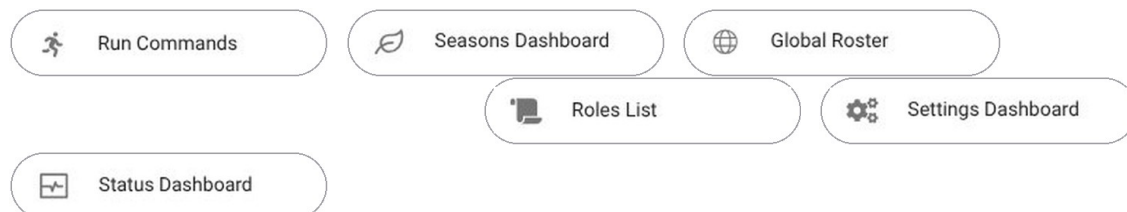
Part B covers all tasks marked ✓ for Roster Coordinators. Part C covers the additional tasks available to Overall Coordinators only.

1. Getting Started with Rostas

Rostas is built primarily for desktop access, though it can also be used on a tablet.

The Rostas Views

When you open Rostas you will see these views in the left-hand sidebar. Tap the relevant view to navigate to that area of the system.



The Rostas left-hand sidebar — tap any view to navigate to that area.

The Run Commands view is your main working area. This is where you trigger all roster actions — sending emails, building the roster, and sending notifications. Each button runs a single action and shows you the result when it is done. After tapping a button, Rostas queues the action and runs it within about 1 minute. A *Complete* message appears in the Status column when done — always check this before moving on.

Rostas Search Run commands

Run commands

Roster commands

0. REFRESH CALENDAR

Refresh Seasons Calendar
Re-calculate all roster dates, holidays, and exclusions

1. SYNC VOLUNTEERS

Sync volunteers from Infodile
Pull latest member data from infodile

2. SEND ROLE PREFERENCE EMAILS

Send Music role preference emails
Email Music volunteers to set their role preferences

Send Nourish role preference emails
Email Nourish volunteers to set their role preferences

Send Sunday role preference emails
Email Sunday volunteers to set their role preferences

3. SEND AVAILABILITY EMAILS

Command history

Command	Parameters	Status	Requested_By	Requested
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	11/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshSeasonsC...		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/2

Current Roster

Service_Date	Role	Volunteer_Name	Status	Roster
19/4/2026	Guitar Acoustic	Connor Parsons	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Guitar Acoustic	Sam Parsons	Pending	Mus
19/4/2026	Sound Tech	Alani Moala	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Sound Tech	Lesley Smith - McDon...	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Electric	Andrew Wallace	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	Drums	Caleb Marshall	Filled	Mus
19/4/2026	keys	Lisa Parsons	Filled	Mus

Date Roster

Day Week Month Today

April 2026

Mo Tu We Th Fr Sa Su

01 02 03 04 05
06 07 08 09 10 11 12
13 14 15 16 17 18 19
20 21 22 23 24 25 26
27 28 29 30

Run Commands — your main working area. Each button triggers one roster action. The Command history panel shows results.

Reading Results

Every action writes a result message in the Command history panel. Common results:

- **Filled: 12, Pending: 3, Unfilled: 0** — roster built successfully. Pending means a volunteer marked Unsure but has been provisionally assigned.
- **Unfilled: 2** — two slots could not be filled. Review the roster and handle manually.
- **Sent to: 14 volunteers** — notification emails dispatched.
- **Error: ...** — something went wrong. Note the message and contact tech support if it repeats.

The Roster Cycle

Each roster follows the same sequence of steps. Run them in order — skipping a step or running them out of order can produce unexpected results.

Timing tip: Send availability emails at least 2-3 weeks before the first date of the new season. Allow volunteers 5-7 days to respond before building the roster.

Normal roster workflow: Step 0 → Step 1 → Step 2 → Step 3 → Step 4 → Step 5 (Preview — check before sending) → Step 6 (Send notifications).

3. Step 0 — Refresh the Seasons Calendar



Run Commands

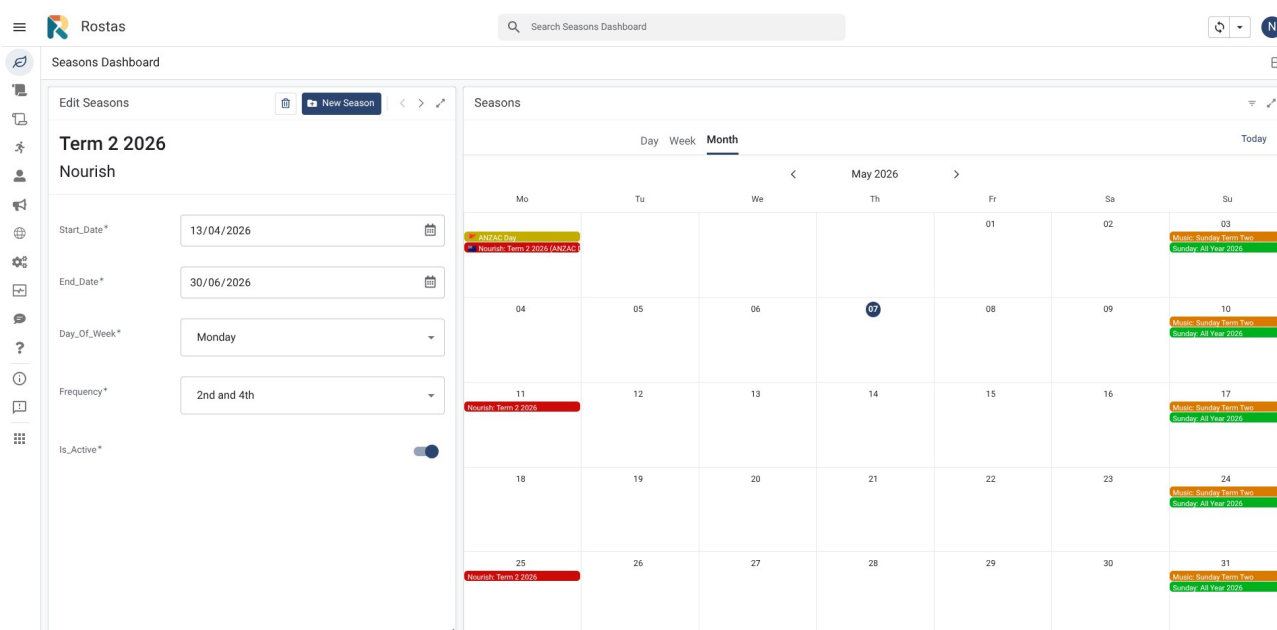


Seasons Dashboard

Run this at the start of each roster build and any time you make changes to season dates. It recalculates all roster dates, overlays NZ public holidays and school holidays, and updates the calendar view.

Step 0 — Refresh calendar

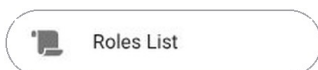
In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **0. Refresh calendar**. Wait for the result message to confirm completion. Check the Seasons Calendar view to confirm dates look correct.



Seasons Dashboard — month calendar view showing all active seasons colour-coded by roster type. Select or create a season in the Edit Seasons panel on the left to view or edit start/end dates, day of week, frequency, and active status.

Always run Step 0 after editing season start/end dates, adding a new season, or at the beginning of a new roster cycle.

Step 2 — Role Preferences



Role preferences tell the system which roles each volunteer is willing to do. The system needs this information before it can build the roster.

Option A — Volunteers Set Their Own Preferences

Volunteers receive a personalised link and tap through each role, choosing 'Yes I do this', 'Happy to fill in', or 'Not for me'.

Step 2 — Send role preference emails

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **2. Send role preference emails**. Volunteers receive an email with a personalised link. Allow a few days for responses before building the roster. Check who has responded in the Preferred Roles view.

Option B — You Set Preferences for the Volunteer

If a volunteer is not comfortable using the link, or for new volunteers who have not yet set preferences, you can set their roles directly in Rostas.

Open the **Preferred Roles** view. Select the volunteer on the left, then review and edit their role assignments on the right.

Preferred Roles view — select a volunteer on the left to see and edit their role assignments on the right.

Rostas

Seasons Dashboard
Roles List
Preferences
Run Commands
Volunteer Details
Comms_Dash
Global Roster
Settings Dashboard
Status Dashboard
SMS and Email
Help
About
Feedback
App Gallery

Roster
+ Add

Sunday
Sunday

Music
Sunday

Nourish
Monday

Volunteer List

Full_Name	Active
Alani Moala	Active
Alex McKenzie	Active
Andrew Larsen	Active
Ben Johnston	Not Active
Bronnie Van Lith	Active
Bruce Lobban	Active
Carolyn Parker	Active
Chelce Marshall	Active
Chris Beale	Active
Christine Cambie	Active
Claire Besseling	Active
Cole Lobban	Active
Coral West	Active
David Ririkore	Active
Denise McKenzie	Active
Dennis Flett	Active
Dianne Hunger	Active
Ella Madden	Active

Andrew Larsen's Roles

Sync Roles

Andrew Larsen's Roles

☐	Boiled/Salad Potatoes	Andrew Larsen
☐	Chicken or Fish	Bronnie Van Lith
☐	Dishwashing Helpers	Andrew Larsen
☐	Event Greeters	Andrew Larsen
☐	Event Musicians	Andrew Larsen
☐	Fresh Bread	Andrew Larsen
☒	Hosting Guests	Andrew Larsen
☐	Kitchen Manager	Andrew Larsen

Roles List view — all active roles with minimum and maximum people required. Tap a role to view or edit its details.

When to use each option: The Roles List view shows all active roles and their settings. The Preferred Roles view shows per-volunteer assignments. Send the email link at the start of a new season; set preferences directly in Rostas for day-to-day adjustments or less tech-confident volunteers. For some rosters coordinators may prefer to set roles themselves.

Preferred Roles — Three-Panel Tile View

The Preferred Roles view includes a three-panel dashboard layout that gives a visual overview of every volunteer's role preferences for a selected roster. Select a roster on the left, browse volunteers in the middle, and see colour-coded role tiles on the right.

The three panels

Reading the colour-coded tiles

How to use the three-panel view

Step 1 — Select a roster

Tap a roster type in the left panel (e.g. **Sunday**). The middle panel refreshes to show only volunteers who serve in that roster.

Step 2 — Select a volunteer

Tap a volunteer name in the middle panel. Their role preferences load into the right panel as colour-coded tiles.

Step 3 — Refresh the tiles

After selecting a volunteer, tap the **sync button** (the circular arrow icon at the top right of the screen). This refreshes the role tiles to show the selected volunteer's preferences. The tiles will not update automatically until you tap sync.

Always tap the sync button after selecting a volunteer. This is a known AppSheet limitation — the role tiles in the right panel are cached and do not refresh automatically when you tap a new volunteer name. Tapping the circular arrow icon (top right) forces a full refresh and the correct tiles will appear. This extra tap is only needed after changing the selected volunteer, not after changing the roster type.

When to use the three-panel view

- **Before building a roster** — quickly check which volunteers have Primary roles set for key positions.
- **After receiving role preference responses** — verify that a volunteer's selections look right.
- **When finding a manual replacement** — see at a glance who else can fill a specific role.

- **Onboarding a new volunteer** — confirm their role preferences have been recorded before the next roster build.

To change a volunteer's role preferences, use the editable Preferred Roles list (the single-volunteer detail view) rather than the three-panel dashboard. The three-panel dashboard is read-only — it shows preferences but does not let you edit them. See Option B above.

Volunteer Frequency Settings

Frequency settings control how many times per month a volunteer can be rostered for a given roster type. The roster engine strictly enforces these caps.

To set or update frequency:

1. In Rostas, go to the **Volunteer Details** view. Select the volunteer from the left panel.
2. Use the arrow buttons (< >) to switch between roster types if the volunteer serves in more than one roster.
3. In the **Max Days Rostered** panel (bottom centre), tap 1, 2, 3, or 4 to set the monthly maximum. The default is 4 for weekly rosters, 2 for fortnightly rosters.
4. Add a note if helpful (e.g. '4th Monday only' or 'family commitments 1st Wednesday').
5. Save. The change takes effect at the next roster build.

The screenshot displays the Rostas Volunteer Details view. On the left, a sidebar lists various dashboard options, with 'Volunteer Details' selected. The main area is divided into four panels. The top-left panel shows a list of volunteers, with Connor Parsons highlighted. The top-right panel, titled 'Roster Assign List', shows Connor Parsons' assignments for May 2026, including dates and roles. The bottom-left panel, titled 'Availability Choices', shows Connor Parsons' availability for May 2026, with options for May 3 and May 10. The bottom-right panel, titled 'Edit Current Roster', shows Connor Parsons' roster for May 2026, with the frequency set to 4 times per month.

Volunteer Details view — volunteer list on the left, Roster Assign List (top centre), Availability Choices (bottom centre), and Edit Frequency panel on the right.

Edit Frequency Availability
Open Avail...
<
>
↗

Music

Volunteer_ID
Alani Moala

Rostered x Times Each Month

1

2

3

4

Notes

Frequency settings panel — tap a number to set the monthly cap for that roster type. Use the arrows to switch between roster types.

Frequency caps are enforced automatically at roster build time. A volunteer who has already reached their monthly cap will not be assigned to any further dates in that month, even if they are marked Available.

6. Step 3 — Send Availability Emails



Run Commands

Availability emails go to all active volunteers for your roster type. Each volunteer receives a personalised link showing the upcoming dates. They tap each date to mark themselves Available, Unsure, or Can't make it, then tap Save.

Step 3 — Send availability emails

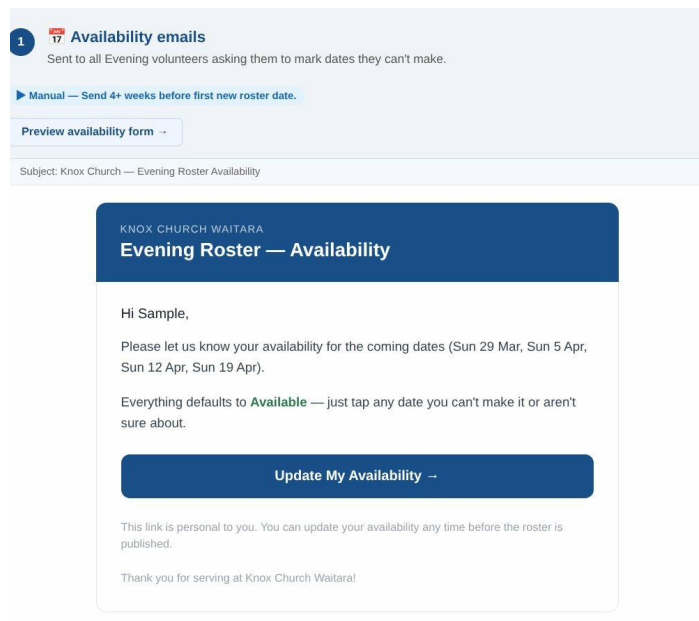
In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **3. Send availability emails**. The result confirms how many emails were sent. Allow 5–7 days for volunteers to respond. Volunteers who do not respond are treated as Unavailable at roster build time.

The screenshot shows the Rostas application interface. On the left, the 'Run commands' menu is open, highlighting '3. SEND AVAILABILITY EMAILS'. The main panel shows the 'Command history' for 'refreshactions', all marked as 'Complete'. The 'Date Roster' panel on the right displays a calendar for April 2026, with volunteers assigned to various roles like Nourish, Music, and Sound Tech.

Command	Parameters	Status	Requested_By	Requested
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	11/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshSeasonsC...		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26
refreshactions		Complete	newsletters@waita...	10/4/26

Service_Date	Volunteer_Name	Status	Roster
19/4/2026	Guitar Acoustic	Completed	Mus
19/4/2026	Guitar Acoustic	Pending	Mus
19/4/2026	Sound Tech	Completed	Mus
19/4/2026	Sound Tech	Completed	Mus
19/4/2026	Electric	Completed	Mus
19/4/2026	Drums	Completed	Mus
19/4/2026	keys	Completed	Mug

Run Commands — Step 3 (Send availability emails) and Step 4 (Build roster) buttons. The Command history panel on the right shows completed actions.



The availability email volunteers receive — a personalised link takes them straight to the form.

The Three Availability States

- ✓ Available** — The default starting state for all dates.
- ? Unsure** — Signals caution. The volunteer may be provisionally assigned.
- ✗ Can't make it** — Immediately removes them from the scheduling pool for that date.

Everything starts as Available — volunteers only spend time changing the dates they cannot make.

Knox Church Waitara
Sunday Roster
Availability Form

Hi Alani,

Tap any date to change your availability. Everything starts as Available — only change the ones you can't make.

● Available
● Unsure
● Not available

APR 27 Monday ✓ Available	MAY 11 Monday ✓ Available	MAY 25 Monday ✗ Can't make it
JUN 8 Monday ✓ Available	JUN 22 Monday ? Not sure	JUL 6 Monday ✓ Available

[Save my availability](#)

The availability form — volunteers tap each date card to cycle through Available, Unsure, and Can't make it, then tap Save.

What if someone missed the email?

You can update a volunteer's availability directly in Rostas via the **Volunteer Details** view. Select the volunteer from the left panel, then use the Availability Requests panel (bottom right) to find the date and update their status.

Automatic SMS nudge for non-responders

After availability emails are sent, Rostas automatically sends a follow-up SMS to any volunteer who has not yet responded — no manual action required. The nudge fires once per cycle, a set number of days after the emails were sent, and only goes to volunteers who still have no upcoming availability response on record.

- You send availability emails (Step 3). The system records the send date automatically.
- After N days (default: 2), the daily background process checks who has not yet responded.
- Non-responders receive a short SMS nudge with a direct link to their availability form.
- The nudge fires **once only** per email cycle — it will not repeat.
- The cycle resets automatically the next time availability emails are sent.

To adjust the nudge timing or wording: Go to Settings Dashboard and search for AVAILABILITY_SMS_NUDGE_DAYS (set 1–5 days) and AVAILABILITY_SMS_NUDGE_TEMPLATE (edit the SMS text). Placeholders available: [Name], [RosterType], [Link].

The nudge SMS respects all the usual controls — SMS_ENABLED, quiet hours, and individual volunteer SMS opt-outs. Opted-out volunteers are silently skipped and counted as Skipped in the daily run log, not as errors.

Step 4 — Build the Roster



Run Commands



Global Roster

The roster engine assigns volunteers to roles based on their availability and role preferences. It works through four priority tiers and within each tier selects the volunteer who has been rostered least recently. When Relational Rostering is enabled, a second pass tries to bring household members and preferred buddies together on the same dates — see Relational Rostering for full detail.

The Four Priority Tiers

Step 4 — Build roster

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **4. Build roster**. The Music roster can take up to 10 minutes — this is normal. The system builds the next 8 weeks of dates by default (configurable per roster type in Settings — `ROSTER_BUILD_WEEKS_{Type}`). Check the result message: Filled, Pending, and Unfilled counts. Review the roster in the Global Roster view before sending.

Reviewing the Result — The Traffic Light System

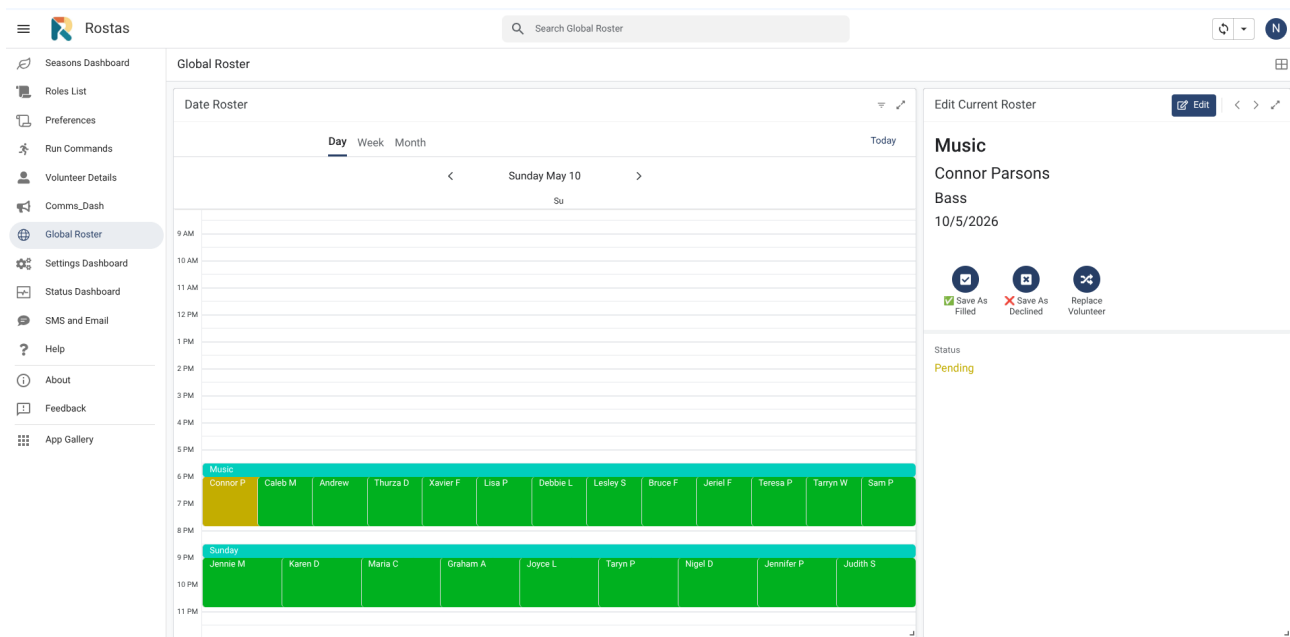
Do not send notifications until you have reviewed the roster. Check for Unfilled slots and any obvious problems first. Once notifications are sent, volunteers receive their assignments immediately.

Editing the Roster Before Sending

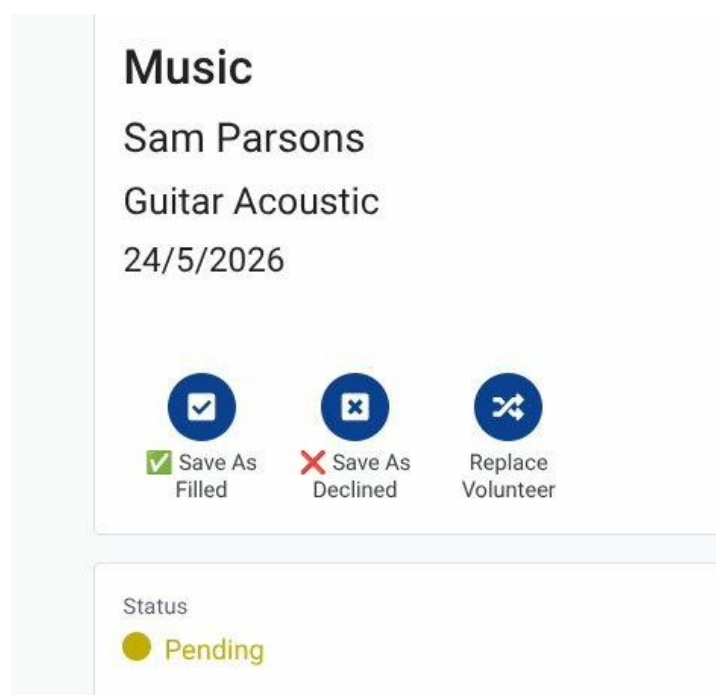
In the Global Roster view, tap or click any assignment to open the edit panel on the right. Take particular notice of any red (unfilled) dates — these may require you to find a replacement or it may be workable to have fewer volunteers on duty that week.

You also have the following options at this stage:

- **Replace Volunteer** — a drop-down offers a list of possible replacement volunteers.
- **Save as Filled** — manually confirm a Pending (Unsure) assignment.
- **Save as Declined** — this automatically starts the SMS replacement chain to find a substitute.



Global Roster Day view — calendar view with Day, Week, and Month tabs. Tap any assignment to open the edit panel on the right with Save As Filled, Save As Declined, and Replace Volunteer options.



The assignment edit panel — Save As Filled confirms a Pending assignment; Save As Declined starts the SMS replacement chain; Swap Volunteer lets you manually select a replacement.

Step 5 — Preview Communications

Before sending notifications, use the **Comms Dashboard** view to see exactly what every communication step will look like — notification emails, reminder emails, SMS messages, and the volunteer reply pages.

Step 5 — Preview communications

In Rostas → **Comms Dashboard**, select a roster type from the list on the left. A full grid of communication cards appears on the right — each card represents one step in the volunteer communication journey. Tap any card to open a live preview. Check volunteer names, roles, dates, links, and message wording. Close the preview and proceed to Step 6 when satisfied.

Comms Dashboard view — select a roster on the left, then browse the full grid of communication previews on the right. Each card opens a live preview of that communication step.

Keep any wording changes generic and appropriate for all roster types, or revert changes afterwards so the next coordinator does not encounter problems.

Step 6 — Send Notifications



Run Commands

Notifications go to every volunteer with a Filled or Pending assignment. Each volunteer receives an email with their role and date, and a link to confirm (for pending) or decline. An SMS is also sent.

Step 6 — Send notifications

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **6. Send Notifications**. The result confirms how many volunteers were notified. Volunteers receive their email and SMS within a few minutes.

What volunteers receive: Each volunteer gets an email showing their name, role, and dates rostered. The email includes a *Can't make it* link. If they tap it, the SMS replacement chain runs automatically — coordinators do not need to do anything when this happens. There is also a link to a simplified printable roster. For Pending (Unsure) assignments, volunteers are shown *Yes, I can make it* and *Can't make it* buttons.

Manual Replacement



Global Roster

Use manual replacement when a volunteer contacts you directly — for example, they phone to say they cannot make it and suggest someone else, or you need to make a swap yourself without waiting for the SMS chain.

Manual replace

Go to Rostas → Global Roster or Volunteer Details view. Select the assignment you want to change. Tap **Replace Volunteer**, then select the replacement from the dropdown. Save. The system processes the swap within 1 minute. Check the Status column — it changes from Pending to Done when complete.

The replacement volunteer receives an automatic notification after a manual swap, with the usual links to the "I can't make it" button, roster view, and print roster.

11. The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps 'Can't make it' in their notification email, the system automatically begins contacting other available volunteers by SMS one at a time.

What happens automatically:

- The system finds the next suitable available volunteer for that role and date.
- It sends them an SMS with a link to accept or decline.
- If they **accept** → they are added to the roster and the chain stops.
- If they **decline or do not respond** within 2 hours (standard) or 15 minutes (urgent/imminent events) → the next volunteer is contacted.
- If no one accepts → the coordinator receives an email letting you know the slot is still unfilled.

Preferred buddies get first refusal. When Relational Rostering is enabled, a volunteer's preferred buddy (and household members) are offered the replacement slot first, ahead of the general candidate list. See Preferred Buddies for full detail.

Quiet Hours: SMS messages are not sent between 9:00 PM and 7:00 AM NZ time. If the chain is running overnight, it pauses and resumes in the morning. Quiet hours can be adjusted in Settings — search for 'Quiet'.

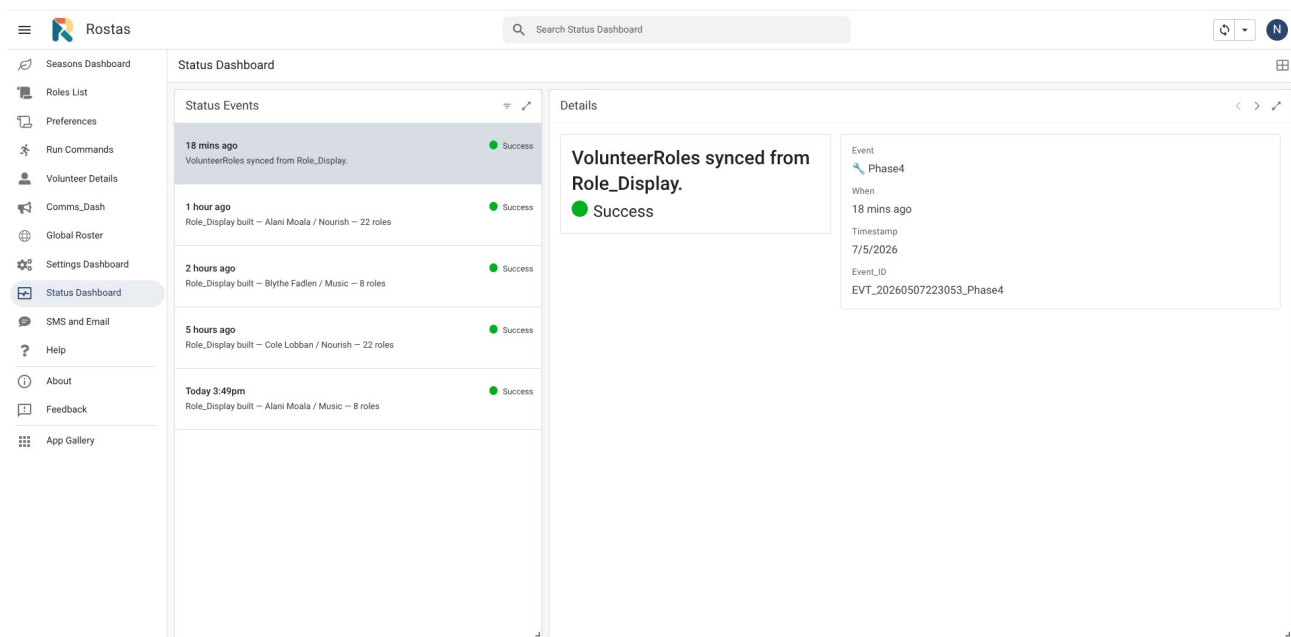
Fairness — Being replaced has one coded consequence: When a volunteer is replaced — whether they tapped Can't make it or were manually swapped — the system remembers. The next time a replacement is needed for a role they can do, they are given gentle priority to be contacted first. Once they serve in any capacity, this priority is automatically cleared.

12. Checking the Status Dashboard

Status Dashboard

The Status Dashboard shows the status of all notifications sent from Rostas — emails, SMS reminders, and replacement requests. Check it after running any notification step to confirm delivery. If an error appears, use the **Email Tech Support** button to send an error report that automatically contains the error detail.

Note: the full Audit Log is accessible to Technical Support only. If something does not look right, contact Tech Support and send the error message.



Status Dashboard — all system events with timestamps and success/error indicators. Tap any row to see full details in the right panel.

Common things to look for:

- **SMS FAILED** — a text message did not deliver. Usually a Twilio issue. Note the error and contact Tech Support if it persists.
- **Chain exhausted** — no volunteer accepted the replacement. The slot is still unfilled.
- **Assignment not found** — a Manual Replace request used an incorrect assignment. Check and resubmit.

If you see repeated errors, do not keep retrying. Note what you were doing and the error message, and contact tech support. Retrying a failed action can sometimes create duplicate assignments.

Relational SMS Email — One View, Four Controls

The Relational SMS Email view is your single place to manage four per-volunteer settings: SMS opt-out, Email opt-out, family pairing, and preferred buddy. Select any volunteer from the **Vol Opt Picker** list on the left to see and edit their settings in the Details panel on the right.

Relational SMS Email view — select a volunteer from the list on the left to view their connected family members and edit all four per-volunteer settings in the Details panel on the right.

What the Details panel shows

Managing Volunteer SMS and Email Opt-outs

Volunteers can opt out of receiving roster SMS messages and/or emails at any time using a self-service preferences link that appears at the bottom of every Rostas email, on the SMS reply page, and on the availability and role preference form success screens. Coordinators can also view and override any volunteer's opt-out status from the Relational SMS Email view.

How volunteers opt out

Every email sent by Rostas includes a "Manage email and SMS preferences" link in the footer. Tapping it opens a simple self-service page where the volunteer can toggle SMS and email on or off independently. Changes take effect immediately — no sync is required.

- Every roster notification email
- Every reminder email (sent before each service)
- Every availability request email
- Every role preference invitation email
- The SMS replacement respond page (YES / NO buttons)
- The availability form success screen
- The role preference form success screen (volunteer mode only)

Coordinator override — Relational SMS Email view

The Relational SMS Email view shows all volunteers with their current *SMS opted out* and *Email opted out* status. Select any volunteer from the list on the left to see and edit their opt-out flags in the Details panel on the right. Two **NO / Yes** toggle buttons appear — tap **Yes** to record an opt-out, tap **NO** to reinstate normal sending. Changes save immediately.

Opted-out volunteers are counted as **Skipped** in send results — not as Errors. A result showing "Skipped: 2" alongside sent counts is expected when opted-out volunteers are bypassed.

Volunteers who have never received a Rostas communication

cannot reach the self-service preferences page themselves — the link requires a personalised volunteer ID in the URL. If a volunteer requests an opt-out before receiving their first email or SMS, use the Relational SMS Email view to set their status directly.

Relational Rostering — Pairing Households and Buddies

Relational Rostering is an optional behaviour layer on top of the four-tier engine. When enabled, after the engine has filled every slot using the normal availability + role + fairness logic, a second pass examines the result and tries to bring related volunteers onto the same service dates wherever it can do so without breaking any other rule.

What "relational" means here: Two kinds of relationship are recognised — **family/household** (auto-detected from Infoodle) and **preferred buddy** (chosen by the coordinator or volunteer in the Relational SMS Email view). The engine treats both as soft preferences, never hard requirements.

Why relational rosters helps

- **Families serve together.** Parents and teens on the same Sunday means one car trip, one supervision conversation, and a shared sense of contribution.
- **Buddies have a steady partner.** Volunteers who like working alongside a particular person are more likely to say yes and less likely to drop out.
- **Replacements are warmer.** When someone declines, the first SMS goes to their buddy or family member, not a stranger.
- **Doesn't override fairness.** The tier system and frequency caps still apply first. Relational pairing only nudges within the candidates the engine would already have chosen.

How to turn it on or off

Toggle Relational Rostering

Go to **Settings Dashboard → Quick Controls → RELATIONAL_ROSTERING_ENABLED**. Tap the toggle: **True** turns it on system-wide, **False** turns it off and the engine reverts to standard tier-based assignment with no pairing pass. Changes take effect at the next roster build.

Settings Dashboard → Quick Controls — RELATIONAL_ROSTERING_ENABLED and the three test mode toggles, all in one place.

Order of operations during a build

Relational pairing is a soft preference, not a guarantee. If a household member or preferred buddy isn't available, isn't in the same roster, or would exceed their frequency cap, the engine leaves the slot as the tier pass assigned it. Don't expect every family or buddy pair to land together every week — just more often than they would by chance.

Preferred Buddies

A preferred buddy is one other volunteer this person likes to serve alongside. The setting is per-volunteer and one-directional — volunteer A can list volunteer B as a buddy without B reciprocating. Reciprocal buddies are stronger signals to the engine but not required.

Setting a preferred buddy

Add a buddy

In Relational SMS Email view, select the volunteer in the Vol Opt Picker list. In the Details panel, tap the **Preferred_Buddy** dropdown and choose another volunteer. Save. The change takes effect at the next roster build.

What the engine does with the buddy

- **Build phase:** If both buddies are in the candidate pool for the same role on the same date, the engine prefers to keep them on that date together (within the same tier and fairness window).
- **Replacement chain:** When the original volunteer declines, the buddy is the first person contacted by SMS, ahead of the general candidate list.
- **Notifications:** No special treatment — buddies receive standard notifications.

One buddy per volunteer. The dropdown holds exactly one preferred buddy. If a volunteer has two close colleagues, pick the one whose schedule overlaps theirs most often.

Family Pairing

Family pairing uses household relationships imported from Infoodle. The **Connected Volunteer Names** field in the Relational SMS Email Details panel shows who Rostas has detected as household members for the selected volunteer. This list is read-only — to change it, edit the household in Infoodle and run a volunteer sync.

Roster Together / Not Together

Each volunteer has a per-volunteer toggle in the Details panel: **Family Members Rostered Together If Possible**. Two options:

- **Roster Together** — the engine will try to put this volunteer on the same date as their household members during the pairing pass.
- **Not Together** — exclude this volunteer from family pairing. Useful for parents who deliberately serve on opposite Sundays to share childcare, or teens who prefer to serve independently.

Both household members must agree. If a parent has Roster Together = ON but their teen has Roster Together = OFF, the engine treats the pair as *not* seeking pairing for that combination. Both volunteers must opt in.

Common scenarios

Same-roster only. Family pairing happens within a single roster type. A parent on the Music roster and a teen on the Sunday roster won't be paired — different rosters serve at different times.

When the master toggle is OFF

If `RELATIONAL_ROSTERING_ENABLED` is set to False in Settings → Quick Controls, the per-volunteer Roster Together / Not Together and Preferred_Buddy settings have no effect on roster builds. The settings remain visible and editable in the Relational SMS Email view, ready to take effect if the master switch is later turned back on.

Step 1 — Volunteer Sync from Infoodle



Run Commands

Infoodle is a membership database. Rostas syncs volunteer data from Infoodle every morning at 2am automatically. You can also run a manual sync at any time using the Run Commands view.

Run a manual sync when:

- A new volunteer has been added to Infoodle and needs to appear in Rostas immediately.
- A volunteer's contact details (email or mobile) have changed in Infoodle.
- A household has been edited in Infoodle and you want the Connected Volunteer Names in the Relational SMS Email view to reflect the change.
- You are about to build a roster and want to make sure you have the latest data.

Step 1 — Sync volunteers from Infoodle

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap **1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle**. The sync runs in two steps and takes about 1-2 minutes. The result confirms how many volunteers were updated.

Important: Volunteer name changes, household membership, and Group/Roster membership are only editable in Infoodle, not in Rostas. Always update volunteer details in Infoodle first, then run a sync.

Adding a New Volunteer

New volunteers must be added to Infoodle first and assigned to the correct Infoodle group for their roster type. Once in Infoodle, run a manual sync and they will appear in Rostas. You will then need to set their role preferences before they can be included in a roster build. If they belong to a household with existing volunteers, the Connected Volunteer Names will populate automatically after the sync.

Settings and Configuration



Settings Dashboard

System settings control how Rostas behaves — coordinator contacts, reminder timing, message wording, and which features are active. All settings are managed through the **Settings Dashboard** view in Rostas. Settings are grouped by category; tap a category to see its settings, then tap any row to view details and edit the value in the right-hand panel.

Settings Dashboard — Settings Categories on the left, the settings in the selected category in the middle, and the editable detail view on the right.

Two types of editable fields: Boolean settings (on/off) use a True / False toggle button pair. Text settings use a free-text field. Numeric settings use a button selector — tap the value you want. Never edit a setting's *key name* — only the value.

Contacts — Coordinator Contact Details

Each roster type has its own coordinator name, email, and mobile number used in outgoing messages, escalation alerts, and the SMS replacement chain. The general COORDINATOR_NAME / EMAIL / PHONE keys are used as fallbacks where no type-specific value is set.

Phone numbers must be in +64 international format with no spaces — e.g. +64211234567. An incorrectly formatted number will cause SMS delivery to fail silently.

Message Wording — Email Notification Templates

These settings control the wording of the roster notification email sent to volunteers at Step 6. Use the **Comms Dashboard** to check how changes look before sending to volunteers.

Timing & Behaviour — Reminder Settings

These settings control when and how reminder messages are sent to volunteers in the days before a service. Reminder emails and SMS are sent automatically — no manual action is required once these are configured.

Message Wording — SMS Replacement Chain Templates

These settings control the wording of all SMS messages sent during the replacement chain — when a volunteer declines and Rostas works through the backup list to find a replacement.

Message Wording — SMS Provider

Rostas supports two SMS providers: **Twilio** and **ClickSend**. The active provider is controlled by the SMS_PROVIDER key in the Message Wording category — no code changes are needed to switch. **Twilio is the current active provider**. ClickSend is retained as a switchable alternative.

Switching providers: Set SMS_PROVIDER = clicksend to switch to ClickSend, or SMS_PROVIDER = twilio to switch back. No other changes needed — credentials for both providers are stored in Settings.

Timing & Behaviour — Roster Engine

These settings control how far ahead rosters are built, how long volunteers have to respond, and how quickly the SMS replacement chain moves between contacts.

Quick Controls — Four Global Toggles

The Quick Controls category contains four global on/off toggles that affect the whole system. All four use a True / False toggle in the Settings Detail View panel on the right. These must be correctly set before go-live and should only be changed deliberately.

- SMS_TEST_MODE → **False**
- EMAIL_TEST_MODE → **False**
- SMS_ENABLED → **True**
- RELATIONAL_ROSTERING_ENABLED → coordinator's choice. Start with **False** to verify the standard build first, then switch to **True** once you're happy with it.

If you are unsure whether the system is in live or test mode, check the Status Dashboard — it shows a *Test Mode active* banner when either test mode is on.

Tech Support Only — Settings to Leave Alone

The Tech Support Only category contains settings that are visible in the Settings Dashboard but should not be edited by coordinators. Each is explained below so you understand what it does and why it is restricted.

This is the URL of the volunteer-facing web app. It is generated by Google Apps Script and does not change unless the script is redeployed from scratch. Redeployment is a rare technical operation. When it happens, every link previously sent to volunteers stops working until this setting is updated.

What to do: Tech support will handle the update. See Part D for the technical procedure.

A comma-separated list of Infoodle group numbers that Rostas pulls from during the volunteer sync.

Why it's restricted: Adding an incorrect group ID causes the sync to attempt to pull from a non-existent group. Removing a group ID means those volunteers disappear from Rostas on the next sync.

Maps each Infoodle group ID to a roster type, using the format
499:Sunday,464:Music,502:Nourish.

Why it's restricted: The format is precise — a stray comma, missing colon, or roster type name that doesn't exactly match ROSTER_TYPES will silently break the volunteer sync. Always ask tech support to update this setting.

Holds the comma-separated list of active roster types — e.g. Sunday,Music,Nourish.

Why it's restricted: Adding a name here alone does nothing useful. A new roster type also requires coordinator contact keys, build-weeks settings, Infoodle group mapping, roles, and a season. Use the **Add Roster** feature in Settings instead — it scaffolds everything in one step. See Adding a New Roster Type.

Infoodle credentials (Site Code, Client ID, Client Secret) and **Twilio credentials** (Account SID, Auth Token, From Number) are also in the Tech Support Only category. These are private API keys — treat them like passwords.

When to Contact Tech Support

Most day-to-day operations are fully self-contained in Rostas. The situations below require more technical involvement:

- The volunteer web app URL has changed and needs updating (after a system redeployment).
- Repeated errors appear in the Status Dashboard that do not resolve on their own.
- SMS messages stop delivering to volunteers.
- The system triggers need to be reinstalled (e.g. after a technical issue).
- Any change to Infoodle connection settings or API credentials.
- Relational rostering produces unexpected pairings or the toggle doesn't seem to be having effect.
- Anything that requires opening the Apps Script editor.

Adding a New Roster Type



Settings Dashboard

New roster types can be added by an Overall Coordinator directly through Rostas. The process takes about 5 minutes and the system scaffolds all required Config keys automatically.

Before you start: Confirm the Infoodle group for the new roster type exists and you have its numeric Group ID. If the group has not been created yet, create it in Infoodle first, add the relevant volunteers to it, then come back here.

Step 1 — Add the Roster Type in Rostas

Step 1 — Add the Roster Type in Rostas

Go to Rostas → **Settings Dashboard** → **Add Roster**. Fill in the Roster Name, Coordinator Name/Email/Phone, Calendar Time Slot, and Infoodle Group ID. Save the row. This automatically queues an addRosterType command.

Step 2 — Wait 1 Minute

Step 2 — Wait 1 Minute

The command poller picks up the addRosterType command and adds all Config keys: COORDINATOR_{TYPE}, COORDINATOR_{TYPE}_EMAIL, COORDINATOR_{TYPE}_PHONE, SEASONS_SLOT_{type}, ROSTER_BUILD_WEEKS_{type}. It also adds the type to ROSTER_TYPES and INFOODLE_GROUP_MAP. Check the Command history panel — the result shows the number of keys added.

Step 3 — Add Roles in Roles List

Step 3 — Add Roles

Go to Rostas → **Roles List**. Add each role for the new roster type — set **Roster_Type** to the new name exactly. Set **Is_Active = Active**, and set Min/Max People as needed.

Step 4 — Add a Season

Step 4 — Add a Season

Go to Rostas → **Seasons Dashboard**. Add a new season — set start and end dates, frequency (Weekly or Fortnightly), day of week, and **Is_Active = TRUE**.

Step 5 — Refresh Calendar and Buttons

Step 5 — Refresh Calendar and Buttons

In Rostas → Run Commands: run **0. Refresh calendar**, then run **7. Maintenance → Refresh command buttons**. New Build, Send, and Preview buttons appear for the new type.

Step 6 — Import Historical Data (if applicable)

Step 6 — Import Historical Data

If you have an existing spreadsheet with past assignments, import it now to give the fairness engine accurate history from day one. See Appendix A1 — Import Existing Roster Data. If there is no existing history, skip this step.

Step 7 — Set Preferences and Run

Step 7 — Set Preferences and Run

Set Ministry_Pref for volunteers via Volunteer Details or after Volunteer Sync once the Infooodle group is populated. Send role preference emails if the roster type uses specialist roles. Then follow Steps 3-6 of the Roster Cycle.

Refresh command buttons: Run 7. Maintenance → Refresh command buttons any time the Run Commands panel looks wrong. This is safe to run at any time.

Removing a Roster Type

If a roster type is no longer needed, it can be removed. Historical assignment records are not deleted — they remain in RosterAssignments for reference.

This cannot be undone automatically. If you might need the roster type again, set its season `Is_Active = FALSE` instead — that stops it appearing in builds without removing any data.

Rostas Run Commands

Delete via Run Commands

Go to Rostas → **Run Commands** → **Step 7 Maintenance**. A *Delete Roster type* button appears for each active roster type. Tap the button for the type you want to remove. The system processes the deletion within 1 minute. Check Command history for the result.

Coordinator-Triggered Decline and Replace



Global Roster

The standard Manual Replacement lets you pick a specific replacement volunteer directly. Decline and Replace is different — it marks a volunteer as declined and hands control to the automated SMS chain, which contacts available volunteers one by one until someone accepts. When Relational Rostering is enabled, the chain begins with the preferred buddy and household members.

Quiet hours apply: If you trigger Decline and Replace between 9pm and 7am NZ time, the SMS chain queues until 7am. For urgent same-day slots, contact potential replacements directly in parallel.

D1. Import Existing Roster Data

The Import Existing Roster function loads a manually-made roster into Rostas. It is used when setting up Rostas for the first time with an existing roster spreadsheet, or when seeding historical data before go-live so the fairness engine has accurate assignment history from day one.

Access required: This function is only accessible from the Apps Script editor. It requires access to the Google account that owns the spreadsheet, and (for AI cleaning) an OpenAI API key stored in Script Properties.

Prerequisites

Step-by-Step: Pivot Format (Recommended)

Step A — Open the Apps Script Editor

In the Rostas spreadsheet: **Extensions → Apps Script**. All actions are run from the Knox Roster menu at the top.

Step B — Create the ImportPivot Tab

Find the **Phase9_ImportRoster** script and click **Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → Setup — Create Pivot tab**. Delete the sample rows (rows 2–4) before pasting your data.

Step C — Paste Your Existing Roster

Copy the roster grid from your source spreadsheet — including the header row with dates and the role column. Paste into cell A1 of the ImportPivot tab. Row 1: Roles | 13/04/2026 | 27/04/2026 | ... Row 2+: Soup | Jane Smith | Bronnie H | ...

Step D — Run AI Cleaning (Recommended)

In the Phase9_ImportRoster Script menu → **Import Existing Roster → 1. Clean roster with AI**. The AI resolves nicknames, informal names, and minor role name variations. The cleaned version is written back into ImportPivot. Review before importing.

If AI cleaning fails: Check that the OPENAI_API_KEY is present in Script

Properties. You can proceed without AI cleaning — names that do not match will be flagged as "Unmatched names". Fix them in ImportPivot and re-run.

Step E — Run the Import

Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → **2. Import (Pivot format)**. Select the Roster Type and confirm. Results: ✓ Written — ❌ Skipped — ⚠ Unmatched names — ? Unknown roles. Correct highlighted cells and re-run until zero unmatched names and zero unknown roles.

Step F — Seed Volunteer Roles from Import

Phase9_ImportRoster Script menu → **Import Existing Roster → 4. Seed volunteer roles from import**. Creates VolunteerRoles entries for each volunteer-role pairing found. Does not overwrite existing entries.

Step G — Seed Volunteer Frequency from Import

Phase9_ImportRoster menu → **Import Existing Roster → 5. Seed volunteer frequency from import**. Counts how many times each volunteer appears in the imported data and creates VolunteerFrequency entries.

After steps F and G: Check the Volunteer Details view for a few volunteers to confirm their frequency counts look right before running the first build.

Alternative: Flat Format

Setup — Create the ImportRoster Tab

Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → Setup — Create Flat tab. Columns: A = Service_Date (DD/MM/YYYY), B = Role_Name (exact match), C = Volunteer_Name (exact match), D = Import_Status (leave blank). Then run: **Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → 3. Import (Flat format)**. Follow Steps F and G above afterwards.

After the Import

Do not re-import: Running with the same data is safe (rows are skipped) but running with a modified copy will create duplicate assignments.

Managing the Nickname Map

Each time AI cleaning resolves a new nickname it saves the mapping to the Nickname_Map tab for future imports. To view or edit: **Knox Roster → Import Existing Roster → Setup — Manage nickname map.**

Troubleshooting — Import

D2. After a Webapp Redeployment — Sync Preview URLs

Every time the Apps Script web app is redeployed, Google assigns a new WEBAPP_URL. The Rosters tab stores a Preview_URL column that must be updated whenever this changes.

Symptoms of a stale URL: The Comms Dashboard in Rostas shows broken preview links, or volunteers receive broken links in notification emails.

Step 1 — Update WEBAPP_URL in Settings

In the Apps Script editor: **Deploy → Manage deployments**. Copy the new web app URL. In Rostas → Settings Dashboard → Tech Support Only, find WEBAPP_URL and paste the new URL. Save.

Step 2 — Sync Preview URLs

In the spreadsheet menu: **Knox Roster → Developer tools → Sync Roster Preview URLs**. Reads WEBAPP_URL and writes the correct ?view=preview&roster=X URL for every active roster in the Rosters tab. Inactive rosters have their Preview_URL cleared automatically.

Step 3 — Confirm

Open WEBAPP_URL?view=preview in a browser. The roster type selector should load. If it shows a permissions error, check the deployment is set to **Anyone** access.

D3. Audit Log Pruning

The Audit_Log tab records every system event. Over time this tab grows large. The pruning function trims it to a manageable size without deleting recent entries.

One-Time Setup

Install the Pruning Trigger

In Phase9_ImportRoster → **Setup — Audit Log Pruning**. Installs a weekly time-based trigger. Run this **once at go-live**. Do not run again — duplicate triggers cause double-pruning.

Manual Prune

Prune Now

In the Dashboard Script → **Prune Audit Log Now**. Immediately trims the Audit_Log. Safe to run at any time.

What gets kept: All ERROR-level entries are always retained. INFO entries older than the configured retention window (default 90 days) are removed.

D4. Clean VolunteerRoles Tab

The VolunteerRoles tab can accumulate blank rows or duplicates over time. The cleanup function removes these safely.

Run Cleanup

In the spreadsheet menu: **Knox Roster → (run from menu)** — the function is `cleanVolunteerRoles` in `Maintenance.gs`. If it is not in the menu, open the Apps Script editor, select `cleanVolunteerRoles` from the function dropdown, and click Run. It removes rows with a blank `Volunteer_ID` or `Role_ID`, rows where `Role_Type` is not `Primary` or `Fillable`, and duplicate `Volunteer_ID + Role_ID` combinations.

Safe to re-run: The function only removes invalid or duplicate rows — it never deletes a valid, unique role assignment.

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